

SDeltaPhi-72 - Useful and Useless

Transition-Opening Usefulness and Closure-Producing Efficiency

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Abstract

This working paper defines useful and useless within the SDeltaPhi Formalism. It rejects the ordinary collapse of usefulness into efficiency, productivity, speed, immediate applicability, or low cost. Conversely, it rejects the collapse of uselessness into inefficiency, difficulty, slowness, or high cost.

Within SDeltaPhi, useful means transition-opening capacity: the ability of a structure, concept, question, practice, or artifact to open new questions, reveal hidden cost attribution, create new observation coordinates, preserve re-entry paths, and make further redesign possible. Useless means closure-producing efficiency: a structure may appear valid, efficient, realistic, orthodox, practical, safe, or productive while closing questions, hiding cost, blocking re-entry, and thickening default power.

The distinction matters because many historical and contemporary systems become useless not when they stop working, but when their apparent usefulness begins to prevent new questions from entering. Conversely, high-cost inquiry, difficult critique, or initially inefficient experimentation may be useful when it opens a new judgment axis and reveals costs that the dominant default could not see.

1. Introduction

SDeltaPhi often speaks of low-cost transition, but this must not be mistaken for ordinary efficiency worship. Low cost is not the same as apparent efficiency. A transition can be cheap for one actor because verification, repair, re-entry, silence, or residual risk cost has been transferred to another actor. In such a case, what appears efficient may be structurally useless.

The ordinary language of usefulness is too narrow. It often treats something as useful if it produces quick results, reduces visible friction, fits an existing institutional demand, or makes a dominant default easier to continue. But SDeltaPhi asks a different question: does the structure open further transition, or does it close transition under the label of usefulness?

Therefore, this paper introduces the distinction between transition-opening usefulness and closure-producing efficiency.

2. Core Proposition

The central propositions are:

Useful is not mere efficiency.

Useless is not mere inefficiency.

A thing may be useful even when it is slow, expensive, difficult, strange, or initially unproductive, if it opens a new question, reveals hidden cost, produces a new observation coordinate, or makes redesign possible.

A thing may be useless even when it is efficient, valid, accepted, orthodox, realistic, profitable, or institutionally convenient, if it closes questions, hides cost, suppresses re-entry, or converts a dominant default into an unquestionable judgment axis.

The shortest formulation is:

Useful = transition-opening capacity.
Useless = closure-producing efficiency.

3. Definitions

3.1 Useful

Useful refers to a structure that opens transition. It enables new questions, new observation coordinates, new cost attribution, new World-Binding, new re-entry paths, or new redesign possibilities.

Useful does not require immediate low cost. It may be high-cost at first. Its value is not determined by short-term efficiency, but by whether it expands the field of possible transition without merely externalizing hidden cost.

3.2 Useless

Useless refers to a structure that produces closure while appearing valid, useful, efficient, realistic, orthodox, safe, or practical. Uselessness in SDeltaPhi does not mean that something has no function. It may function very well. The problem is that it functions by closing further questions and preventing re-entry.

A structure becomes useless when its apparent usefulness makes it harder to see what it hides.

3.3 Transition-Opening Capacity

Transition-opening capacity is the ability of a structure to make further movement possible. It can open a new question, lower the cost of seeing a hidden burden, create a new interpretive route, or allow a suppressed exception to re-enter the field.

3.4 Closure-Producing Efficiency

Closure-producing efficiency occurs when an efficient or accepted structure reduces visible friction while raising the cost of alternative paths, disagreement, exception persistence, or re-entry. It is not useless because it fails, but because it succeeds too well at closing the field.

4. Why Efficiency Is Insufficient

Efficiency is not rejected. SDeltaPhi does not romanticize waste, difficulty, or cost. But efficiency must be audited. A structure is not useful merely because it is efficient. It must be asked:

- Whose cost was lowered?
- Whose cost was increased?
- Which questions were made easier to ask?
- Which questions became harder to ask?
- Which re-entry paths were preserved?
- Which re-entry paths were closed?

Efficiency becomes suspect when it operates as a label that prevents cost attribution from being examined.

Fast does not mean useful.
Cheap does not mean useful.
Practical does not mean useful.
Realistic does not mean useful.
Efficient does not mean useful.

The question is whether the structure opens or closes transition.

5. Useful as Transition-Opening

A useful structure may be difficult at first because it introduces a new judgment axis. It may require new language, new evidence, new documentation, new coordination, or new institutional forms. This initial cost does not make it useless.

A useful structure may:

- reveal hidden cost attribution;
- make a previously invisible actor visible;
- reopen a closed question;
- distinguish nominal equality from actual TCC equality;
- distinguish legal validity from cost symmetry;
- distinguish appearance from closure;
- distinguish fiction as falsehood from fiction as World-Binding;
- distinguish human-easy from AI-easy;
- create a re-entry path for previously excluded interpretations.

In this sense, useful means that a structure increases the future possibility of better transition.

6. Useless as Closure-Producing Efficiency

A useless structure may remain socially respected. It may be orthodox, productive, profitable, administratively simple, legally valid, or historically authoritative. It becomes useless when it prevents the cost of its own operation from being seen.

Common closure-producing labels include:

- efficient;
- practical;
- orthodox;
- realistic;
- safe;
- legitimate;
- natural;
- traditional;
- common sense;
- human-only;
- public interest;
- fair to everyone.

These labels are not automatically wrong. But when they block further cost audit, they can become closure devices.

7. Default Power, Time, and Accumulated Habitation

New questions do not become low-cost merely because an old default power is historically distant. The opposite often happens. A default power can thicken over time because many people have lived inside it, repeated it, taught it, defended it, inherited it, and built institutions around it.

Default power is not weakened merely by age;
it is often thickened by accumulated habitation.

A default is not only an idea. It is a residence. It provides a shared habitation structure. Over time, that habitation accumulates residents, authority, memory, education, ritual, institution, status, and emotional investment. Therefore, directly negating an old default on the same judgment axis may be extremely high-cost.

A new question becomes lower-cost not when it attacks the old default more loudly, but when it opens a different judgment axis that reveals costs the old default could not see.

Useful is not the power to destroy a default.
Useful is the power to reveal what the default cannot see.

8. Case A: Song Si-yeol, Samu-nanjeok, and Closure-Producing Orthodoxy

This case must not be used to demonize a single historical individual. The point is structural. Song Si-yeol did not invent every form of closure in late Joseon thought, nor did late Joseon contain only closed intellectual paths. New routes such as evidential learning, practical learning, northern learning, Western learning, and other forms of inquiry existed.

The SDeltaPhi question is different. If no one was closed, where did the visible closed tendency come from?

The answer is that closure does not require a single evil actor. It can arise when interpretive difference is translated into moral, political, or existential disqualification. The label samu-nanjeok did not merely disagree with an interpretation. It converted interpretive difference into high-cost exclusion.

Different interpretation -> doctrinal threat -> samu-nanjeok -> moral/political exclusion -> increased re-entry cost.

From the SDeltaPhi-72 perspective, the orthodox structure may have appeared useful: it protected order, continuity, legitimacy, and doctrinal coherence. But when the same structure made alternative interpretation prohibitively costly, its usefulness became closure-producing efficiency.

The issue is not whether Song Si-yeol alone caused late Joseon closure. The issue is that a high-authority node can amplify an existing closure pathway by making non-default interpretation expensive to re-enter.

9. Case B: Generative AI and the Human-Only Creativity Default

For a long time, a dominant default held that artificial systems might replace repetitive labor, calculation, or mechanical production, but not creative work. Even after the camera, digital editing, Photoshop, and other technical tools entered artistic fields, this default did not simply weaken. In many contexts, it thickened: real creativity was defended through human intention, authenticity, inner expression, and emotional originality.

Generative AI did not challenge this default merely by arguing against it on the same axis. It introduced a different axis of judgment. Creativity could now be evaluated not only by human interiority, but by output generation, editing cost, deployment speed, stylistic recombination, audience binding, workflow integration, and downstream use.

The important SDeltaPhi point is not that AI has fully replaced human creativity. The point is that AI opened a new judgment axis under which the old default became unstable.

This is a useful case because it shows how an old default may be shaken not by direct denial, but by a new transition field.

10. Relation to SDeltaPhi-71

SDeltaPhi-71 distinguished low-cost redesign from cost externalization. SDeltaPhi-72 extends this distinction into the language of usefulness.

A low-cost transition is not automatically useful. If it lowers visible cost by transferring hidden burden to another actor, it may be efficient but useless. Conversely, a high-cost critique may be useful if it reveals hidden burden and makes redesign possible.

Low-cost redesign is useful only when it does not become cost externalization.

11. Diagnostic Questions

Use SDeltaPhi-72 when a structure is being called useful, efficient, practical, realistic, orthodox, valid, or useless.

Ask:

1. What question does this structure open?
2. What question does it close?
3. Whose cost does it reveal?
4. Whose cost does it hide?
5. Does it create a new observation coordinate?
6. Does it preserve re-entry paths?
7. Does it make disagreement possible without moral or existential exclusion?
8. Does it reduce total TCC, or only transfer cost to less visible actors?
9. Does it become more authoritative merely because many people have lived inside it?
1. 10. Does it open a different judgment axis, or merely fight the old default on the same axis?

12. Do-Not-Use Conditions

Do not use SDeltaPhi-72 to label disliked theories, traditions, persons, institutions, or communities as useless without analyzing closure, re-entry, cost visibility, and transition-opening capacity.

Do not treat high cost as automatically useful.

Do not treat efficiency as automatically useless.

Do not use useful/useless as moral praise or blame.

Do not confuse disagreement with closure.

Do not use historical examples to demonize individuals when the relevant target is structural closure.

Do not use AI creativity examples to claim that human creativity has been fully replaced.

Do not use useful/useless as a final ranking system. It is a diagnostic distinction, not a moral hierarchy.

13. Failure Modes

1. Efficiency Collapse - treating efficient structures as useful without cost audit.
2. Romantic Difficulty - treating costly, obscure, or difficult structures as useful merely because they are hard.
3. Dislike Labeling - calling an unwanted institution useless without diagnosing closure.
4. Moralization Error - using useful/useless as praise/blame rather than transition analysis.
5. Default Attack Error - directly negating a thickened default on the same axis and increasing defensive cost.
6. Historical Demonization - assigning structural closure to a single person without accounting for institutional reproduction.
7. AI Replacement Overclaim - using AI creativity as proof that human creativity is obsolete rather than as evidence of a new judgment axis.
8. Re-entry Blindness - ignoring whether alternative paths can re-enter after the useful label is applied.
9. Habitation Blindness - ignoring how many actors live inside a default and therefore experience direct negation as world loss.
2. 10. Closure Disguised as Usefulness - accepting practical, realistic, orthodox, or efficient labels as sufficient evidence of usefulness.

14. Module Relations

SDeltaPhi-72 links especially to:

- SDeltaPhi-01: minimal core and phase-change formalism.
- SDeltaPhi-03: irreversibility.
- SDeltaPhi-28: default power.
- SDeltaPhi-34: money, capital, and default power.
- SDeltaPhi-56: Transition Completion Cost.
- SDeltaPhi-65: slop as externalized restabilization cost.
- SDeltaPhi-70: fictional habitation, Binding Fiction, and Editing Fiction.
- SDeltaPhi-71: cost attribution redesign.

15. Conclusion

SDeltaPhi-72 redefines useful and useless away from ordinary efficiency language. Useful does not mean fast, cheap, accepted, orthodox, or immediately productive. Useless does not mean slow, difficult, costly, strange, or initially unproductive.

Useful means that a structure opens transition. It creates new questions, reveals hidden costs, allows new judgment axes, preserves re-entry, and makes redesign possible.

Useless means that a structure closes transition. It may appear efficient, valid, practical, realistic, or orthodox, but it hides cost, blocks re-entry, thickens default power, and prevents further questions from entering.

The point is not to reject efficiency. The point is to prevent efficiency from becoming closure.

SDeltaPhi useful = what opens the next question.

SDeltaPhi useless = what closes the world while calling itself useful.